

Session 15: Relationships Between Days

Key Takeaways

- Days one through three describe the environments that God creates, and days four through six describe the inhabitants. Creation is all about ordering and populating the skies and the land.
- Days four and six repeat the similar theme of rulers. Day four is about the rulers above, and day six is about the rulers below.
- The story culminates in the creation of the human rulers below who will partner with God.

The Cosmos of Genesis 1: Days One Through Six

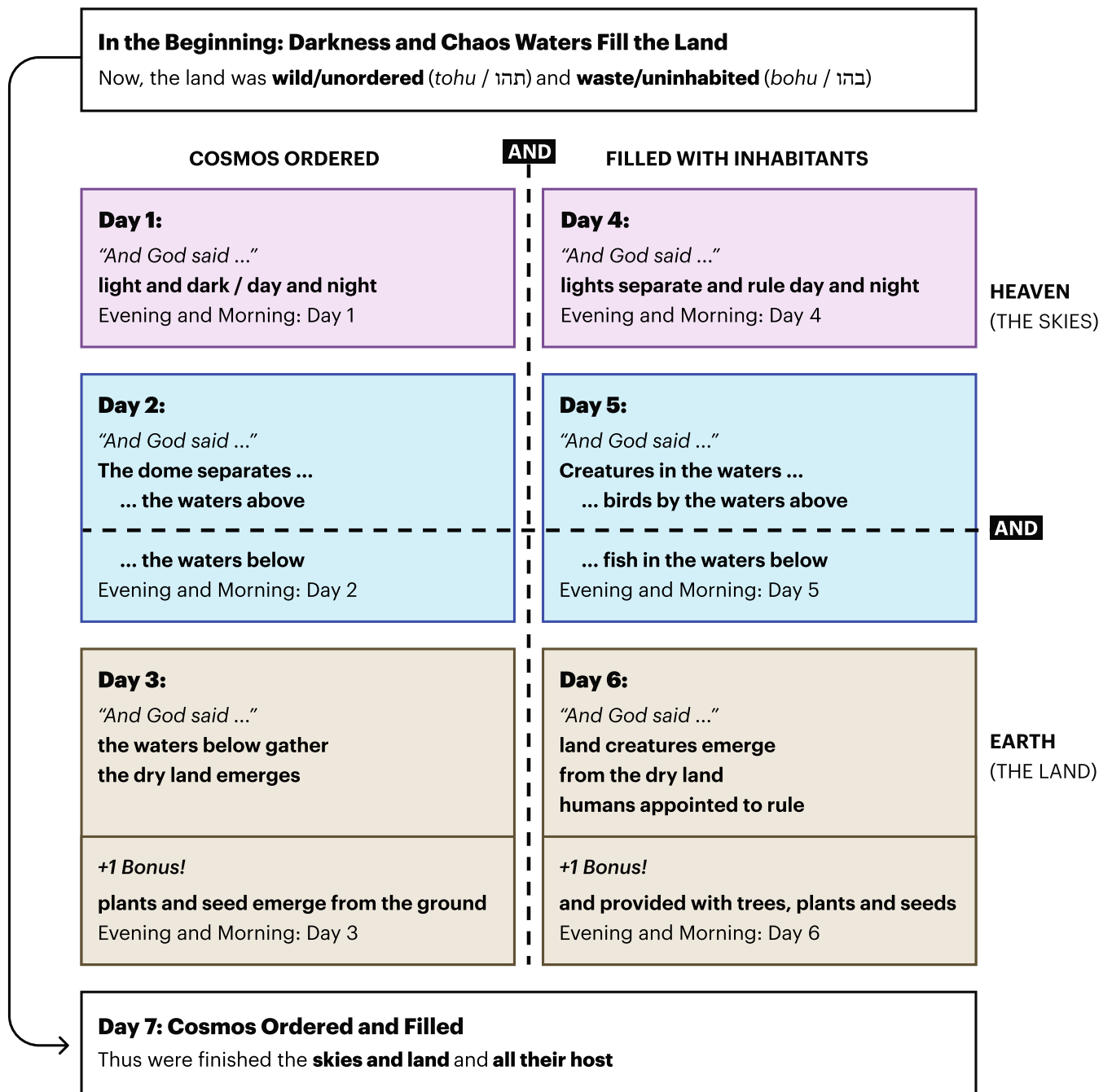
Days One Through Three

Days one through six have been neatly organized as two triads that each address the problems presented in Genesis 1:2—disorder and emptiness.

Days one through three address the problem of creation being unordered and uninhabited as God organizes the cosmos into distinct realms: the heavens above, the middle heaven/earth, and the land below.

Days Four Through Six

Days four through six supply each of these realms with their appropriate inhabitants: the heavenly realm with lights, the middle heaven/earth with birds and fish, and the dry land with creatures and humans.



Origami of Genesis 1. Adapted from David Andrew Teeter by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Design Structure of Days One Through Three

Day 1: God Orders the Heavens

³ **And God said,**
"Let there be light";

and there was light.

4 **God saw that the light was good** ;
and God **separated** the **light** from the **darkness** .

5 And God called the **light** **day** ,
and the **darkness** he called **night** .

And there was evening
and there was morning,
one day (יום אחד) .

Day 2: God Commands the Chaos Waters To Be Split

6 **And God said** ,
"Let there be a **dome**
in the middle of the waters,
and let it **separate the waters**
from the waters."

7 And God made the **dome** ,
and **separated the waters**
which were below the **dome**
from **the waters**
which were above the **dome** ;
and it was so.

8 God called the **dome** **skies** .

And there was evening
and there was morning,
a second day .

Day 3: God Orders the Land

9 **And God said** ,
" **Let the waters** below the skies
be gathered into **one place** (מקום אחד) ,
and let the dry ground be seen";
and it was so.

10 And God called **the dry ground** land,
and the gathering of the **waters** he called seas.
God saw that it was good .

11 **And God said** ,
"Let **the land** sprout vegetation,

4'

vegetative plants that produce seed,
fruit trees
that make fruit according to its kind
which has its seed inside it
upon the land";
and it was so.
12 And the land brought out
vegetative plants
that produce seed according to its kind,
and trees
that make fruit
which has its seed in it,
according to its kind;
and God saw that it was good .
13 And there was evening
and there was morning,
a third day .

Genesis 1-2:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2020).

This design structure invites the reader to compare and contrast the matching elements.

- Days one and three both portray God as addressing the two most iconic images of disorder, chaos, and death in the biblical imagination: darkness and the waters (note that they were already paired in 1:2). We are encouraged to see both as corresponding images of anti-creation.
- Day two is set apart from days one and three because it has the most elaborate “command/fulfillment” structure of the three days. While days one and three each have a command and a short fulfillment, day two has a lengthy, repetitive command followed by an equally lengthy fulfillment. But note that the two halves match, nearly identically. This is a literary embodiment of the theme of day two, which is the complete division between the heavenly and earthly by splitting the waters.

The reader walks away from days one through three with a robust awareness of the makeup of the biblical cosmos.

- Heaven and Earth are mirror realities. The provision of divine light contains the darkness and creates the most basic condition necessary for life to flourish. In a similar way, the provision of the land on Earth pushes back the waters, creating a space where life can flourish.
- God’s “conflict” with the darkness is a foundational image of the spiritual conflict that underlies the story of the Bible. Similarly, God and humanity’s conflict with the chaos-waters can function as an image of the human conflict (the metaphor scheme of humans as chaos waters).
- God’s victory over darkness on day one and the waters on day three happens by speaking a word. Day two focuses on God’s splitting the waters, again by speaking a word. But this is followed by an act of creation as God separates the chaos waters.

Every single part of this network of images will be developed throughout the remainder of the biblical narrative.

- Waters // darkness // death // enemies
- Dry land // light // life // refuge
- God splitting the waters to create life // God's victory over chaos and evil

We are invited to consider the design of days four through six in a similar way. And the comparisons and contrasts will again yield rich results about biblical imagery.

Design Structure of Days Four Through Six

Day 4: God Delegates Heavenly Rulers

- 14 **And God said,**
" **Let there be lights**
in the expanse of the skies
to **separate** the **day** from the **night**,
and let them be for signs
and for festivals and for days and years;
- 15 and let them be for **lights**
in the dome of the skies
to give **light** on the land";
and it was so.
- 16 And God made the two great **lights**,
the great **light** to **rule** the **day**,
and the small **light** to **rule** the **night**;
and also the stars.
- 17 And God placed them
in the dome of the skies
to give light on the land,
18 and to **rule** the **day** and the **night**,
and to **separate** the **light** from the **darkness**;
and God saw that it was good.
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- 19 And there was evening
and there was morning,
a fourth day.

Day 5: God Apportions the Waters Above and Below

- 20 **And God said,**
"Let **the waters** swarm with swarms of living creatures,
and let birds fly **above the land**

against the face of the dome of the skies."

21 And God created the great sea monsters
and every living creature that moves,
B with which the waters swarmed after their kind,
and every bird of wing after its kind;
and God saw that it was good .

22 And God blessed them, saying,
A' "Be fruitful and multiply,
and fill the waters in the seas,
and let birds multiply on the land."

23 And there was evening
and there was morning,
a fifth day .

Day 6: God Delegates Earthly Rulers

24 And God said,
"Let the land bring out living creatures
according to their kind,
cattle
and creeping things
and beasts of the land
according to their kind";
and it was so.

25 And God made
the beasts of the land
according to their kind,
and the cattle
according to their kind,
and the creepers of the ground
according to its kind;
and God saw that it was good.

26 And God said,
"Let us make human
in our image,
according to our likeness;
and let them rule
over the fish of the sea

and over the birds of the sky
and over the cattle
and over all the land
and over every creeper that creeps on the land ."

27 And God created human in his image,
in the image of God he created him;
male and female he created them .

28 And God blessed them,
"Be fruitful and multiply,
and fill the land,
and subdue it;
and rule
over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over every living creature that creeps on the land ."

29 And God said,
"Behold, I have given to you
every plant producing seed
that is on the surface of all the earth,
and every tree which has fruit producing seed;
it shall be food for you;
30 and to every beast of the land
and to every bird of the sky
and to every thing that moves on the land
which has animal life in it,
every green plant for food";
and it was so.

31 And God saw all that he had made,
and behold, it was very good.

And there was evening
and there was morning,
a sixth day .

Genesis 1-2:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2020).

This design structure invites the reader to make new contrasts and comparisons.

- God's delegated rulers mirror each other. On day four, the sun and moon rule day and night. Note that the stars are not included in the delegated rule; rather, they make up the part that is ruled (the darkness

and night). Similarly, on day six, the man and woman function as a ruling pair over the land and animals. This last point fosters the comparison between the objects in the heavenly and earthly realm that are subjected to the rule of God's images: the stars and the animals (consider how these implicitly come together in Gen. 3).

- Notice how all three days have an extra created object that sticks out of the other lists: the stars (// the rulers), the sea monsters (// Leviathan), and the cattle (// Behemoth).

When this overlapping set of design structures are laid on top of each other, we can see what scholar David Andrew Teeter calls "literary origami." The six days of Genesis 1 are arranged along two "folds," a vertical axis that forms two matching triads, and a horizontal axis that forms each triad into a mirror shape.

Reflection Question

Summarize what you learned about the structure of days one through six in Genesis 1.



Module 4: A Tour of the Cosmos

SESSIONS 16-22

Explore the significance of each element of the cosmos, as understood by the ancient Israelites, to bring Genesis 1 into clearer focus.